CHAPTER 7 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

Women and the War

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Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

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When a war never named a single woman in its battle reports, how do we measure what women actually changed?

The War Nobody Photographed

BEHIND EVERY ARMY

For every soldier in the field, someone kept the world running behind him. Across both North and South, women took over farms and family businesses, managed plantations, and sewed and raised money for the armies.

In the South especially, with so many white men away, women ran households and fields — while enslaved women carried an even heavier burden, and many seized the chaos of war to escape toward Union lines and freedom.

Clara Barton — photographic portrait, public domain (Library of Congress).

Clara Barton, the “Angel of the Battlefield”

MATHEW BRADY STUDIO

Barton brought supplies and nursing directly to the front lines, sometimes under fire. After the war she founded the American Red Cross.

Clara Barton — wartime photograph, Mathew Brady studio, public domain (Library of Congress).

A Revolution in Care

NURSES AND ORGANIZERS

Nursing had been considered no job for a respectable woman. The war changed that overnight. Thousands of women — like Clara Barton and Dorothea Dix — nursed the wounded, and the U.S. Sanitary Commission, largely run by women, organized supplies and medical care on a massive scale.

Black women such as Harriet Tubman served the Union as nurses, cooks, and scouts — Tubman even guided an armed raid that freed some 700 enslaved people in South Carolina.

Harriet Tubman — photograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

Harriet Tubman

AT THE VERY FRONT

Already famous for leading the enslaved to freedom on the Underground Railroad, Tubman served the Union as nurse, cook, and scout — and helped guide the raid that freed some 700 people along the Combahee River.

Harriet Tubman — photograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

At the Very Front

SPIES AND SOLDIERS

Some women went right to the fighting. Spies like Elizabeth Van Lew (for the Union) and Belle Boyd (for the Confederacy) passed secrets across the lines. A few hundred women, historians believe, disguised themselves as men and fought as soldiers.

Each of these women pushed against the hard limits her society placed on her — and the war gave her a reason, and an opening, to push.

"Filling Cartridges at the United States Arsenal, Watertown, Massachusetts" — wood engraving, Harper's Weekly, 1861, public domain.

The Vivandière

"DAUGHTER OF THE REGIMENT"

Some women marched openly with the army as vivandières — carrying water and supplies, tending the wounded, and sometimes carrying the colors under fire.

A vivandière ("Daughter of the Regiment") — photograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

CLARA BARTON, REFLECTING AFTER THE WAR

I may be compelled to face danger, but never fear it, and while our soldiers can stand and fight, I can stand and feed and nurse them.

A Door Pushed Open

WHY IT MATTERS

The war didn't grant women equality — they could not vote, and most returned to older roles when it ended. But it proved what women could do: run institutions, manage money, practice medicine, organize nationally.

That proof fed directly into the postwar women's rights movement. Historical significance asks not just 'what happened?' but 'what did it change, and for how long?' — and by that measure, women's war work mattered far beyond 1865.

"Infamous!" — General Orders No. 28, the "Woman Order," issued by Maj. Gen. B. F. Butler, New Orleans, 1862 — broadside, public domain (Library of Congress).

Measure the Significance

YOUR TURN

You'll weigh the many roles women played and practice historical significance — judging not just what women did, but how much it changed and how long the change lasted.